

WTC Snow Camp for Orange County Modjeska Group at Table Mountain

This past weekend was snow camp, the last of the outings for the 2010 Sierra Club Wilderness Travel Course which I've been volunteering for since going through as a student in 2008. Previous years I had hoped in vain for a blizzard to hit while we hiked in only to get cold but otherwise depressingly clear weather.

2008:



2009:



2010:



Friday morning as I was leaving for the forecast was for -18 degree wind chill, winds 20-40 mph with gusts up to 60, and 2-4 inches of snow accumulation the first night.

YES!!!

I arrived at the bus pickup with an extra spring in my step and tried to impart my joy into the students and other leaders who were all sadly somewhat less enthused about the weather conditions.



I made sure to get plenty of pictures of everyone while they were still warm, smiling, and hadn't yet lost fingers to frostbite.

Compared to the Joshua Tree trip snow camp leaves rather late (9 am) so all of us are generally awake.



Well, most of us anyway.



We had a long bus ride and arrived in Bishop in the late afternoon. The students were given only an hour to eat and change into their snow gear so we had a bit of a frenzied time.

Back on the bus we drove up the mountain road towards the South Lake / Sabrina Lake split and I was greatly cheered by the view out the window.



Blizzard camp 2010 here we come!



Our group cheerfully waved goodbye as the bus dropped off the other Orange County group a few miles below Lake Sabrina.

Now it was our turn.



The bus stopped where the road becomes blocked by snow a few miles below Table Mountain campground. We poured out and started assembling gear and putting on layers.



Some of us brought more gear than others as demonstrated by our tough and fearless group leader Wayne.





Conditions improved rapidly and we were soon buffeted by wind carrying small snowflakes and ice crystals.



Things improved rapidly once we made camp. Note the horizontal snow.



After getting my tent set up and Kim situated I was off to check on the students. In the process I stamped out a path through the camp but it was quickly filling in with the snow which was now falling heavier.

The students were doing quite well considering the conditions and I pitched in here or there with advice or minor help where I could. Once the tents were up people generally dove inside to get out of the snow and wind.

Once everyone was headed for their sleeping bag I returned to the tent and headed off myself.



The next morning we awoke to roughly 6 inches of fresh snow. Everything looked beautifully untouched.



We made coffee and breakfast while waiting for the sun to hit us. Once it did it became much warmer and several layers could come off.



As soon as everyone was thawed out we mounted up and marched the students further up the hill towards South Lake.



It was a steep hike at times and those of us in the front had the joy of breaking trail through the fresh snow which is always a bit of a kick in the pants.

Once we arrive at South Lake lunch was a laid back affair and then it was time for avalanche pits and snow shelters







Why not to walk on a cornice.



I led a small snow shelter activity though conditions weren't exactly ideal.



Returning to camp it was starting to get dark so we all layered up and the students dug us out a snow table.



Everyone had brought food to share and we had quit the feast.



By now it was quite cold and people started to drift off towards their sleeping bags.

There was no additional snow that night but it was much colder.



I woke up that morning to find my contacts had frozen solid in their solution even though I had them wrapped in several layers of insulation and I had to stick them under my shirt to thaw them out.





Again we waited for the sun and once it hit we were all stripping off layers.

We had a talk about bear hanging, food safety, and then proceeded to the camp Hair Competition.







Then it was time to pack up and head out. As we slowly disassembled our tents and shoved everything back in our packs.



Before we could leave I made everyone do a group photo of course.

We were actually over an hour early for the bus so we passed the time with snowball fights, Frisbee, and just kicking back.



And some people did Yoga.





That or they were just hit by a car. Not sure which.



The bus arrived and we headed down the hill towards civilization and the always awesome post-snow camp pizza.





We ate, washed the grease down with beer, and re-boarded the bus for the long drive home.



Kim and I were in charge of the bus on the way home so we showed two movies to help pass the time. The first was Touching the Void about climbing accident where one guy had to cut the rope and thought

he had dropped his partner to his death. It's a great movie and highly recommended if you haven't seen it. The other was the Everest Imax movie which deals with some of the events of the 1996 disaster.

We made it back to Orange County sometime after 9 pm after a successful snow camp. Now it's on to the summer trips!